**St Nicholas of Tolentino RC Church, Lawford's Gate, Bristol BS5 0RE**

**Priest's Office, Assisi Centre, Lawford's Gate, Bristol BS5 0RE tel: 07779677370**
**Parish Office, Assisi Centre, Lawford's Gate, Bristol BS5 0RE tel: 0117-909-0419**
**(Office open: Monday-Friday 10am - 1.00pm)**
**'Borderlands' Charity Office: Assisi Centre, St Nicholas Church tel: 0117-904-0479**
**Parish email: bristol.stnicholasoftolentino@cliftondiocese.com**
**Fr Richard's email: richard.mckay@cliftondiocese.com**
**Clifton Diocesan Website: www.cliftondiocese.com**
**Download this Bulletin from the Parish Website: www.tolentino.org.uk**
**Parish Priest - Rev Richard McKay (tel: 07779677370)**
**Catechesis: Mary Hopper (01275-830788) Caretaking of our buildings: Eddie Mgbeoduru**
**Safeguarding Reps: Mary Hopper (01275-830788) & Paul Bradshaw-Price**
**Parish Administration & Hall/Room Bookings: Office Team (0117-909-0419)**
**Community Stewards: Eustace Tameh (Finance), Margaret Ulloa (Property), Benedicta Lobela Amba (Youth), Epiphania Chipato (Pastoral) Mary Hopper (Catechesis)**

# *THIRD SUNDAY OF LENT*

## *MISSION IMPOSSIBLE!*

What on earth is He doing? No self-respecting Jewish 'holy man' or rabbi would venture into Samaritan country: they are the hated enemy and for sure God had no time for them. They had destroyed the unity of the nation, of the People of God some 600 years earlier - and we and God have long memories! They are outside the concern of God!

And it gets worse: he is speaking to a woman - in public! A Samaritan woman! Even drinking from her cup! And what a reputation she has! Just goes to show this young rabbi knows nothing and is 'beyond the pale'. Like her, he is a disgrace!

To go the excluded of the excluded - to descend into the pit of condemnation: this is Divine Love, this reveals the true nature of God. Not possessive or precious about 'ritual purity', seeming holiness, but passionate to bring love to the loveless, to gather in the most excluded and reveal them to the world as 'closest to the Father's heart'!

***'To the lost Christ shows His face; to the unloved He gives His embrace; to those who cry in pain or disgrace, Christ makes, with his friends, a touching place!'***

**SUNDAY: PARISH MASS at 10.00am** *(Live-streamed)*
*Stations of the Cross approx 12.30pm*

**MONDAY: No Liturgy**

***Jesus said, 'If you only knew the gift of God, you would ask me and I would give you the living water of the Holy Spirit, a spring of water welling up within you to give life in fullness'***

**TUESDAY: No Liturgy**

**WEDNESDAY: No Liturgy**

**THURSDAY: Adoration 11.30am Mass 12.00 noon**

**FRIDAY: Adoration 11.30am Mass at !2.00 noon**
***Lenten Area House Mass* at 7.00pm at 8 Ingmire Road, Eastville BS5 6XD**

**SATURDAY: Adoration 11.30am Mass at 12.00 noon**
***Sacrament of Reconciliation*** after Mass and 4.00-4.30pm

***TODAY*** [1] The **Third Sunday of Lent** celebrates Jesus calling us to conversion and mission, and gifting us with the Holy Sprit to fulfil the mission. Jesus meets the excluded Woman of Samaria, speaks to her deepest need, embraces her with forgiveness and love and sends he back to the villagers that excluded her to evangelise them. She does very successfully! We too are forgiven, loved and sent as missionary disciples - will we do His work?
[2] **We pray the Stations of the Cross** at approximately 12.30pm (ie after refreshments following our 10am Mass). We offer this ancient prayer devotion today for peace in our world - especially between Israel and Palestine, Russia and Ukraine, among the Sudanese people, between US and Iran. Blessed are the peacemakers!
[3] Last year we missed out on the **Missionary Orders annual Collection for 2025**. So we are taking it this week as a **Retiring Collection for the African Sisters of Divine Love. Please be as generous as you can - Lent is a special time for giving of our money especially to the Mission of the Church.**

***NEXT SUNDAY*** [1] The **Fourth Sunday of Lent ('Laetare' or 'Rejoicing' Sunday)** celebrate Jesus the Light of the World brings us from our blindness to New Sight. The healing of the man for blind expresses the power of baptism and the gradual conversion tom Jesus. Are we blind to the presence of Jesus in our lives, in the poor and marginalised? Can we open the yes of our hearts to recognise Him with us?
[2] **We welcome Bishop Bosco, chief shepherd of our diocesan family, who presides at our 10.00am mass, meets the parish community over some food after Mass and then meets with our Parish pastoral Council, Parish Finance Committee, Community Stewards and the Legacy Management Group in a joint meeting. *IT IS SO IMPORTANT THAT ALL OF US MAKE EVERY EFFORT TO BE HERE AND MEET THE BISHOP AFTER MASS.***
[3] This is also **'Mothering Sunday'** when we give thanks for the gift of our mothers, praying for those of them who have died; we pray too for those sisters whose hopes for a child has not been fulfilled and those who have lost a child in the womb or in early years. ***Also our young people will lead most ministries during the Mass.***
[4] Because of the Bishop's visit we are unable to have Stations of the Cross together. Perhaps we can pray the Stations privately this week.

***PRAY FOR THIS WEEK'S PARISH MINISTRY OR MISSION*** We pray today for our **Ethiopian Orthodox Community**. Giving thanks for sisters and brothers in this very ancient Church, going back to the Acts of the Apostles, it is our privilege to host them Sunday by Sunday here at St Nicks.

***DIOCESAN PRAYER*** We pray for the parishes in communion for mission of St Catharine of Alexandria, Frome and St Dominic, Mells, served by Canon Richard

Dwyer, Deacons David Brinn and Richard Mills, Parish Administrator Anna Pang and both their communities. Please also remember Bishop Crispian Hollis, Emeritus Bishop of Portsmouth, who is resident in Mells.

***COLLECTIONS***
GA: £30 + Loose £199.43 + Card Reader £62.24 + S.O. £206.35 = £474.96 - thanks!
**CAFOD FAST DAY** £192.50 (Still open) **Foodbank** £100.00 **Caritas** £8.00 **Flowers** £6.00 **Spanish Mass** £36.23 - many thanks!

***DATES FOR THE DIARY***
10th March School Governors meet at 5.00pm
15th March **Visit of Bishop Bosco, presiding at 10am Mass and meeting with parish**
18th March Parish Pastoral Council meets after 6.30pm Mass
24th March Lenten Reconciliation Service - Bristol Area
at Christ the King, Thornbury 7pm
24th March Feast of St Oscar Romero, martyred Archbishop of El Salvador Mass 7pm
25th March **Feast of the Annunciation** - Adoration at 6.00pm & Mass at 6.30pm
26th March Parish Finance Committee at 7.30pm (via Zoom)
28th March **Celebration of First Reconciliation** at 10.00am
28th March Mass in Shona with the Zimbabwean Community at 1.30pm
29th March **PALM SUNDAY - HOLY WEEK BEGINS**
**Mass & Procession begins in school at 10.00am**
1st April Mass of the Chrism, Clifton Cathedral at 11.00am - all welcome
2nd April **Holy Thursday Mass of the Last Supper** at 7.00pm, watching to midnight
3rd April **Good Friday** Open Air Stations at 11.00am **LITURGY OF THE PASSION 3.00pm**
4th April **EASTER VIGIL MASS at 9.00pm**
**5th April EASTER SUNDAY MASS OF THE RESURRECTION AT 10.00am - ALLELUIA!**
25th April Meet the Curia Day at St Brendan's College
30th April Parish Finance Committee at 7.30pm (on Zoom)
6th May Clergy and PSR's Safeguarding Training 9.30am to 3.00pm
12th May School Governors at 5.00pm
4th July Diocesan Celebration Day at Downside Abbey 10.00am - 4.30pm

***PASTORAL VISIT TO ST NICKS BY BISHOP BOSCO*** **I am delighted to announce that Bishop Bosco on Sunday March 15th will preside at 10am Mass, then meet parishioners as we share some food, followed by a meeting of the Joint Committees** (Parish Pastoral Council, Parish Finance Committee, and The Legacy Management Group, together with the Community Stewards). **Please everyone make it a priority to come and share Mass that day and stay on to meet our Bishop - his first official visit to St Nick's Community.**

***CAFOD LENTEN FAST DAY*** **Why not make every Friday a Lenten Fast Day and to give weekly through the CAFOD envelopes or the Digi-Card Reader as part of your Lenten journey 'breaking the yoke of poverty' and 'bringing true Justice'.**

***Part-Time Parish Administrator (Maternity Cover to 31st December 2026)***
We are recruiting for a Part-Time (14hrs per week) P 11. Administrator to oversee all parish office tasks and support the Parish Priest and Team in the day to day running of the parish. Reporting to the Parish Priest, the successful candidate will have excellent verbal, written and communication skills. They should be organised and pro-active with the ability to work alone and prioritise work demands in an often-busy environment. The Candidate will often be the first point of contact for

enquiries from parishioners and members of the local community with varying needs who will visit the office for help and support. An excellent knowledge of Microsoft 365 programmes and computer skills is required. Any experience in a similar role would be desirable. For further information and an application form, please visit the parish website St Nicholas of Tolentino RC Church, Bristol or by email to paula.asquith@cliftondiocese.com. Full Time Equivalent salary £25k. Closing date (extended): 13th March 2026

***MONTHLY YOUTH-LED MASS*** Let us encourage our young people to fulfil the ministries on Sunday 15th March, (Bishop Bosco will be with us) & on Sunday 19th April.

***WHY LENT?*** We have joined with Christ Jesus' 40 Days in the desert to journey with Him through the desert of silence and prayer, of deprivation and hunger, of thirst and yearning. Why? To grow to become more like Jesus in generosity of spirit, openness of heart, deeper communion with God, a readiness to give of ourselves to the Mission of the Gospel. These 40 Days express our communion with all catechumens of the Church journeying to the great moment of Baptism (or reception into Full Communion with the Church). These 40 Days are our journey to the renewal of our Baptism at Easter when we say again our 'YES' to being plunged into the Mystery of Christ and become truly Christ People, filled with His Spirit and knowing ourselves to be 'Beloved of the Father'. Let us embrace these days of renewal.

***LENT - A SEASON OF RENEWAL*** **[1]** As part of our lenten journey of renewal, we wish to hold **Area Masses each week of Lent** (except Holy Week). **Would you be willing to host such a Mass in your home, welcoming parishioners who live in your geographical area.** We will supply known addresses in the particular area so that the host can invite them to their home for the Mass. If you are willing to host such a Mass in your home, please contact either Richard or the Parish Office Team.
**[2] Try to come to at least one weekday mass each week, and joint the Stations of the Cross on Sundays after Mass**
**[3] Diocesan Lenten Reconciliation Services with Bishop Bosco** - The Bristol Area Service is at 7.00pm on **Thursday 24th March at Christ the King Church, Thornbury, Castle Street, BS35 1HA** - all very welcome with many priests available.
**[4] Lenten Retreats** a) Feb 20-22 at Monastery of Our Lady & St Bernard, Brownshill, nr Stroud GL6 8AL (Also quiet day March 5th; Vocations Weekend 17-19 April)
b) Feb 20-22 at Stonyhurst Christian Heritage Centre, a Carmelite Spirituality Retreat on St John of the Cross apply on-line: ***christianheritagecentre.com***

***THE TRUE FAST - ACCORDING TO POPE FRANCIS***
***"Fast from hurting words and say kind words. Fast from sadness and be filled with gratitude. Fast from anger and be filled with patience. Fast from pessimism and be filled with hope. Fast from worries and trust in God. Fast from complaints and contemplate simplicity. Fast from pressures and be prayerful. Fast from bitterness and fill your heart with joy. Fast from selfishness and be compassionate to others. Fast from grudges and be reconciled. Fast from words and be silent - so you can listen."***

***WORK EXPERIENCE OFFER FOR 1ST AND 2ND YEAR UNIVERSITY STUDENTS***
The Catholic Fund for Overseas Development (CAFOD) and the Society of St Vincent de Paul (SVP) are working together to offer residential work experience for 20 young adults. All accommodation costs, meals and travel to the Office for the week are covered. It will be focussed on CAFOD NATIONAL OFFICE, ROMERO HOUSE, LONDON SE17JB. More information from email: ***KeziaH@svp.org.uk***

***Jesus said, 'If you only knew the gift of God, you would ask me and I would give you the living water of the Holy Spirit, a spring of water welling up within you to give life in fullness'***

***Pope Leo XIV has released the first document of his pontificate, an Apostolic Exhortation called Dilexi te – 'I have loved you'***.
"I share the desire of my beloved predecessor that all Christians come to appreciate the close connection between Christ's love and his summons to care for the poor," Pope Leo writes in the opening paragraphs. "I too consider it essential to insist on this path". God's Option for the Poor leaves us Christians with no option but to follow the Way of Christ, the Way of the Gospel and share God's Option!

***Neurodiversity and our Faith research*** The Catholic Bishops' Conference of England & Wales and Birmingham Newman University are conducting research into Neurodiversity and our Faith. If you're an adult neurodivergent Catholic or a Caregiver of a neurodivergent Catholic, we want to hear from you. Your experiences will help us to become more inclusive and responsive to your needs. To find out more and to fill in our short surveys look here:
www.godwhospeaks.uk/neurodivergent-catholic-surveys
Survey Flyer Caregivers Survey Flyer Adults